lack vitamin B.”

“What is the outcome of a vitamin B deficiency?” she asked, returning to the office.

“It can make the blood too acidic and cause nerve problems. If mothers don’t have enough vitamin D in their milk, their babies will have trouble feeding.”

He turned away to concentrate on his notes, rubbing his neck with his hand. As Léa watched, she felt a sudden urge to reach over and do that for him. She could sense the tension like knots under his skin from everything he took on. Outside, the situation weighed on both of them: the retreating German army was bringing back many Polish and Russian forced laborers, a few of whom were arriving in Glashütte. All were in poor health, and it was already winter, straining the sick bay’s limited resources.

“You’re doing the best you can,” she said, gently, hoping her words would ease his stress.

“Am I?” He drew a breath as if to refocus. “I need to rearrange things, find a more efficient process. I’ve got people standing outside the sick bay waiting to get in, and if I can’t see them within a few hours, they have to return to the factories and won’t be able to get the time off to come back.”

Léa, too, was worried about running out of supplies. She knew she wouldn’t get permission to return to Berlin for many months, if at all. But she had an idea and wanted to share it with Josef to see if it might help.

“I spoke to a Norwegian worker who regularly receives a certain tonic from her family.”

“Which one?”

“Cod liver oil.”

“It’s an excellent source of iodine and vitamins A and D.” He put his pen down. “Can she get more?”

“No, but she suggested we write to the Red Cross, telling them our situation and requesting regular supplies of cod liver oil. Norway is the main source for Europe.”

“We have nothing to lose by trying. All they can do is say no.”

“Was Ewa your first delivery?”

“Oh no, I’ve brought quite a few babies into the world?”

“How many?”

He thought for a moment. “A dozen.” He looked down. “Not all of them